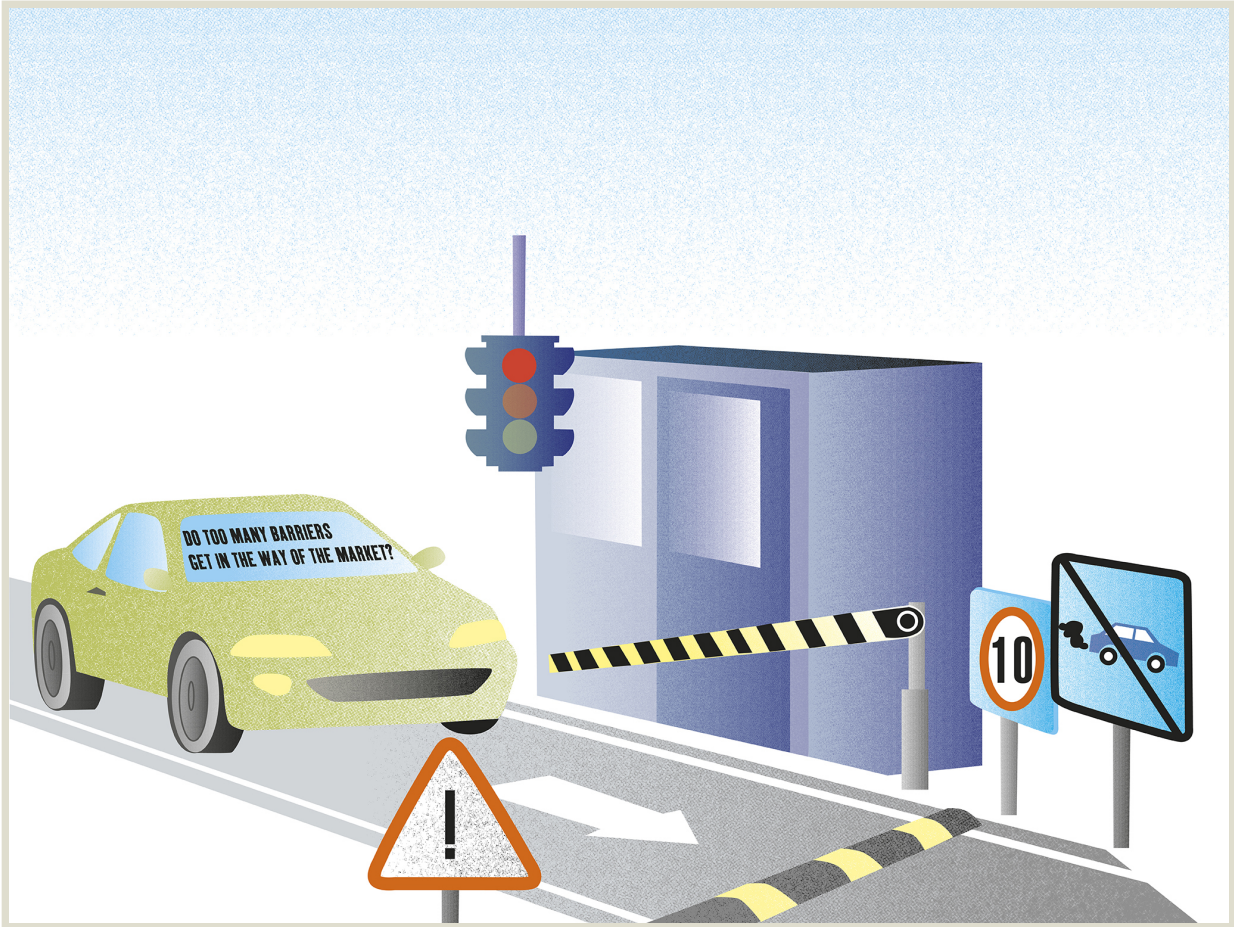




Safer path

Just as traffic laws slow down traffic but make it safer, regulation of the markets restricts businesses but makes them fairer.

Free or equal?

The arguments for and against free markets or government intervention are not purely economic. They are based on politics, too. The choice boils down to freedom versus equality. Unregulated markets, favored by liberal countries, allow people the freedom to choose, but at the price of an unequal society; while centrally controlled economies, advocated by socialist politicians and economists, offer a fairer distribution of wealth but more restrictions. Even in “mixed economies” the balance changes over time, so that since the 1980s, a *laissez-faire* approach has tended to dominate in many countries around the world.